

The goddess Saraswati in the homely form in which she is portrayed today, with a sitar-like *vina* in one pair of hands while her other hands hold a stylus and a palm-leaf manuscript. Detail of a gouache painting from Mysore c. 1835.

The *Mahabharata* transforms into magnificent myth the quarrels and conquests of the five Arya tribes as they pushed on into the Doab country between the Ganga and Yamuna rivers and then across the great Gangetic plain. As they advanced they subdivided into rival clans, each led by chieftains bent on establishing their own *janapada*s (literally ‘people’s feet’, so footholds). The more warlike of the clans expanded by conquest into *mahajanapada*s or city-states, and their clan leaders now increasingly became hereditary rajas as kingship acquired a new sanctity.

The sacred space of the Aryavarta expanded into the more mundane geography of Bharatavarsam, ‘the continent